

Judgment



A judge's bench, formal and empty. The chair is still vacant. The courtroom is not a metaphor we control. The session has not started. It is on the calendar.

Before you gather

- Read Day 8, Judgment, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Acts 17:30–31 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

If this week played on a screen, what ten seconds would you skip?

Leader. A little exposure is enough. You may let someone pass. Shut down oversharing. Then open Acts 17. Judgment is God's verdict, not the group's. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: The chair is empty, not retired. God has fixed a day, and the Judge is the man
He raised from the dead.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Judgment is God fairly judging every person's life and giving what is due according to His holy and righteous standard. For those apart from Jesus the verdict is always guilty, resulting in eternal punishment.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek krisis — a separating, a trial, a decision, a judgment.

MEMORY VERSE • HEBREWS 9:27

And just as it is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment.

Together, open the flashcard for Judgment. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Acts 17:30–31

Paul is preaching to people who are not insiders. God commands all people everywhere to repent, because He has fixed a day. Stay in Acts 17:30–31. The proof is the resurrection. Do not reteach the journal.

The times of ignorance God overlooked, but now he commands all people everywhere to repent, because he has fixed a day on which he will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed; and of this he has given assurance to all by raising him from the dead.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What has God fixed, whom has He appointed to judge, and what proof does Paul give? **CORE**

Leader. A day. A man, Jesus. The resurrection. Judgment is not a mood. It is appointed, personal, and righteous. God has given assurance to all by raising Him from the dead.

2. Paul says God now commands all people everywhere to repent. What does that do to the idea that judgment is only a church topic?

Leader. The bench covers the whole city, including people who find the idea embarrassing. The times of ignorance God overlooked. Now the command is repent. No one is outside the jurisdiction.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Hebrews 9:27 says it is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment. Why do we live as if the second half of that sentence were optional?

Leader. Busyness, entertainment, even ministry can be a way not to look at the chair. Death is appointed. Judgment follows. A feeling that it is 'not yet' does not move the day.

4. Read Hebrews 9:28 right after 9:27. Christ will appear a second time, not to deal with sin but to save those who are waiting for Him. What is the difference between those two futures? **CORE**

Leader. Outside Christ, the day is judgment. In Christ, sin has already been dealt with. The Judge is the Savior. If fear fills the room, read John 5:24: the one who hears and believes does not come into judgment. Do not tell an unbeliever they are already safe.

5. Romans 2:11 says God shows no partiality. Whose sin do we grade on a curve, and whose do we not?

Leader. The curve usually favors people like us. God does not. His standard is His own righteousness. Let that land. Do not turn the night into politics. We stand under the same Judge.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

A real Judge is coming, and His standard is His righteousness, not our excuses.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Make the apology you owe, or stand up for someone being misjudged. Then tell one person far from Jesus that God has fixed a day to judge the world, and that you trust the risen Christ, not your record.

Leader. They stand under the same Judge. If anyone sounds pleased to swing judgment at others, stop them. We do not grade on a curve either. The gospel sentence is repent and

trust the risen Jesus. Deeds without that sentence are not the whole challenge. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, thank You that the chair is still empty and there is still time to repent.
2. We pray for people living as if judgment were a myth. Open their eyes to the risen Judge.
3. Thank You that the Judge is Jesus, who died and rose. Make us eager for Him.

Before you stumble

Do not flatten this into 'Christians never face any evaluation.' Second Corinthians 5:10 says we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ. For believers that is not a condemnation hearing. Justification stands. It is still a real appearing. If that is too much for the room, stick to John 5:24 and Hebrews 9:27-28. Do not tell anyone they are safe apart from faith in Christ.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what would change this month if they believed a day was fixed. Push past 'I would be nicer' to something with a date: a conversation, a habit, an apology. Then ask who the Judge is. The answer is the risen Christ.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Ecclesiastes 12:14. God will bring every deed into judgment, with every secret thing, whether good or evil. Read it if the group thinks only public scandal counts.